BOOKS FOR A PADSHAH

If Akbar was effectively illiterate it did not mean that he was cut off from the seductive world of ideas and stories. Every evening, at the court in Agra, books would be read out to him, books of Islamic, Persian, or Indian origin and, as he grew older, the manuscripts he would listen to would become more eclectic and philosophical, a veritable compendium of the sixteenth-century learned man's library. But as a young man Akbar loved to listen to stories which reflected his own extraordinary destiny—tales filled with valour, excitement, intrigue, and physical prowess. His very favourite story in his teenage years was the somewhat obscure *Hamzanama*, a ninth-century Persian epic which used the character of the hero Amir Hamza, father-in-law of the Prophet, to spin a rollicking fable that mixed folk tales, religious meanderings, and familiar legends. These stories were narrated by a professional qissa-khwan (storyteller), who not only memorized, recited, and improvised these texts but performed them, using a judicious mix of gestures, expressions, and oral modulation which kept alive the exquisite suspense of the story. The stories were performed at the court but a qissa-khwan also accompanied the royal retinue on its travels and on its hunts. It is easy to imagine all the noblemen gathered around the fireside, exhausted after a day's hunt. They may even have been eating kebabs roasted on skewers over the fire, a remnant from Babur's days wandering in the company of nomadic Central Asian horsemen. Under the vaulted sky, the listeners would be entranced as the story unfolded, the shadows shifting across the storyteller's face, his eyes glittering as his hands and words created worlds far beyond the limits of the fireside shadows.

Akbar's favourite qissa-khwan was Darbar Khan whose father, Takaltu Khan, was himself a storyteller in the service of Shah Tahmasp. As a native speaker of Persian, Darbar Khan's facility with the language would have been essential to his popularity because Persian was already greatly prized as the courtly language par excellence. Darbar Khan was given a mansab of 700 and when he died, an eighteenth-century biography noted, he had asked to be buried near the tomb of Akbar's faithful dog, showing a degree of cherished intimacy not many other noblemen could have claimed. Akbar